From RANS Prediction to Hydrofoil Optimization: A Benchmark of Neural Surrogates

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Abstract

Neural flow surrogates are usually compared by field error, although their practical value often lies in the designs they select. We compare a convolutional neural network U-Net (CNN-U-Net), a physics-informed neural network (PINN), a Fourier neural operator (FNO), and a deep operator network (DeepONet) on 381 OpenFOAM computational fluid dynamics (CFD) simulations of hydrofoils in water. Complete families form disjoint training, validation, and final-test sets, and every architecture is trained with three seeds. The models predict Reynolds-averaged Navier–Stokes (RANS) fields, lift, drag, and pressure-based cavitation-inception risk, and then drive the same four-parameter hydrofoil shape-optimization loop. DeepONet gives the lowest mean pressure, C_p, lift, and drag errors on the untouched test families; the PINN is close and has the fastest inference. Inference is 384–665 times faster than OpenFOAM. Across seeds, endpoint solves give mean L/D from 22.10 to 37.47, but a three-level grid study shows that drag remains mesh-sensitive. Field accuracy, force accuracy, search quality, and simulator verification are related but not interchangeable.

1 Introduction

For a hydrofoil operating in water, shape design is an optimization problem wrapped around a flow solver. Each change in camber, thickness, or incidence requires another Reynolds-averaged Navier–Stokes (RANS) solution, so even a modest search can consume hundreds of computational fluid dynamics (CFD) evaluations; neural surrogates move most of that search off the solver by learning the map from geometry and operating conditions to flow and forces [Brunton et al., 2020]. The difficult question is not simply which network minimizes field error, but which one preserves the quantities that determine a useful design.

Convolutional neural network U-Nets (CNN-U-Nets) emphasize local multiscale structure [Ronneberger et al., 2015]. Fourier neural operators (FNOs) mix information globally in Fourier space [Li et al., 2021, Kovachki et al., 2023]. Deep operator networks (DeepONets) separate parameter and coordinate representations [Lu et al., 2021]. Physics-informed neural networks (PINNs) constrain learning with differential equations [Raissi et al., 2019]. Their relative merits may therefore change as the target moves from pressure fields to forces and finally to shape optimization.

Early airfoil-surrogate studies focused on field prediction [Guo et al., 2016, Bhatnagar et al., 2019, Sekar et al., 2019, Thuerey et al., 2020]. More recent benchmarks evaluate surface forces, out-of-distribution accuracy, and computational cost [Bonnet et al., 2022, Li et al., 2023, Yagoubi et al., 2025]. Those metrics establish whether a model approximates CFD, but they do not by themselves establish whether it will make the same design decision. A small, structured force error can be amplified when an optimizer repeatedly queries a narrow region of design space. The missing experiment is therefore a controlled comparison that follows several surrogate families through the same

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optimizer and then checks the selected geometries with new CFD solutions. High-fidelity endpoint verification is standard in surrogate shape optimization, while a matched direct-CFD search provides a stronger reference when its cost is manageable [Li et al., 2022, Shukla et al., 2023].

That experiment is the contribution of this paper; we do not propose a new architecture. We train four representative model families on the same 381 RANS simulations and reserve two complete hydrofoil families for validation. We compare fields, total forces, pressure-threshold cavitation screening, and runtime, then give every model the same three-start hydrodynamic shape optimization (HSO) problem. Fresh OpenFOAM solutions check the four surrogate winners, while a direct OpenFOAM search uses the same starts and budget as a reference. Cavitation risk here means inception inferred from C_p, not a multiphase prediction of cavity evolution.

2 Data and CFD reference

2.1 Design space

The dataset contains National Advisory Committee for Aeronautics (NACA) 0006, 0008, 0010, 0012, 0015, 0018, 2412, 2415, 4412, 4415, 4418, and 4421 profiles generated from the standard four-digit parameterization [Abbott and von Doenhoff, 1959]. For each profile, we simulate angles of attack $\alpha \in \{-4, -2, 0, 2, 4, 6, 8, 10\}^\circ$ and Reynolds numbers $Re \in \{10^5, 2\times10^5, 5\times10^5, 10^6\}$. All cases use liquid water with density $\rho = 997$ kg/m^3 and kinematic viscosity $\nu = 10^{-6}$ m^2/s. With chord $c = 1$ m, the freestream speed is set by $U_\infty = Re\nu/c$; the far-field absolute pressure p_∞ and vapor pressure p_v are 101325 and 2300 Pa, respectively.

Each case is solved with OpenFOAM `simpleFoam` [Weller et al., 1998]. For steady incompressible flow, the mean velocity $\bar{u}_i$ and pressure $\bar{p}$ satisfy

$$\frac{\partial \bar{u}_i}{\partial x_i} = 0, \tag{1}$$

$$\rho \bar{u}_j \frac{\partial \bar{u}_i}{\partial x_j} = -\frac{\partial \bar{p}}{\partial x_i} + \mu \frac{\partial^2 \bar{u}_i}{\partial x_j \partial x_j} - \rho \frac{\partial \overline{u_i' u_j'}}{\partial x_j}. \tag{2}$$

Here, $\mu = \rho\nu$ is the dynamic viscosity, and $-\rho\overline{u_i' u_j'}$ is the Reynolds-stress tensor formed from velocity fluctuations u_i'. The Reynolds stress is closed with the k–ω shear-stress transport (SST) model [Menter, 1994]. Angled freestream velocity is imposed at the inlet and far boundary, and OpenFOAM's `forceCoeffs` supplies total lift and drag after 300 iterations. Cell-centered fields are interpolated to a common 128×64 Cartesian grid over $x/c \in [-1, 2]$ and $y/c \in [-0.75, 0.75]$. Inputs include coordinates, operating parameters, three NACA descriptors, a fluid mask, and signed distance to the profile.

Three simulations with $|C_L|$ or $|C_D| > 5$ are discarded before splitting, leaving 381 cases. NACA 0015 and 2412 provide 64 validation cases for early stopping; NACA 0018 and 4418 provide an untouched 64-case test set used only for final reporting. The remaining 253 cases from eight families train the models. This fixed partition is identical for every architecture and seed, and no validation or test geometry appears in training at another operating point. All retained solves reach iteration 300. The 95th-percentile maximum initial residual at that iteration is 1.27×10^{-4}; the corresponding late-window spans are 0.0059 in C_L and 2.65×10^{-4} in C_D.

2.2 Targets and cavitation-risk definition

The common output vector contains U_x, U_y, absolute pressure p, eddy viscosity ν_t, k, ω, C_p, cavitation margin, C_L, and C_D. Grid fields use masked normalized mean-squared error, while the case-level force targets use normalized mean-squared error. OpenFOAM's kinematic gauge pressure p_k is converted to absolute pressure as

$$p = p_\infty + \rho p_k, \qquad C_p = \frac{p - p_\infty}{\frac{1}{2}\rho U_\infty^2}. \tag{3}$$

For an ambient-pressure value p_a, the pressure-based inception margin is

$$M(x, y; p_a) = p_a + C_p(x, y)\tfrac{1}{2}\rho U_\infty^2 - p_v. \tag{4}$$

A cell is labeled at risk when $M < 0$. We evaluate this label at $p_a \in \{2500, 3000, 5000, 10000, 25000, 101325\}$ Pa. This sweep creates a useful classification test from the predicted C_p field without representing multiphase physics.

3 Surrogates and optimization

3.1 Model families

The **CNN-U-Net** has three encoder/decoder levels, skip connections, group normalization, Gaussian error linear unit (GELU) activations, and base width 16 [Ronneberger et al., 2015]. The **FNO** has width 32, four operator blocks, and 12 retained Fourier modes per direction [Li et al., 2021]. Its update is

$$h_{l+1} = \sigma\big(W_l h_l + \mathcal{F}^{-1}(R_l \mathcal{F}(h_l))\big)\,. \tag{5}$$

Here, h_l is the layer-l feature field, W_l is a learned local linear map, σ is a nonlinear activation, $\mathcal{F}$ and $\mathcal{F}^{-1}$ are the forward and inverse Fourier transforms, and R_l contains the learned spectral weights on the retained modes. The **DeepONet** uses three-layer, width-64 branch and trunk networks with 64 basis functions. Its output has the form

$$\widehat{y}_q(\mathbf{x}; \boldsymbol{\mu}) = \mathbf{b}_q(\boldsymbol{\mu})^\top \mathbf{t}_q(\mathbf{x})/\sqrt{64} + c_q. \tag{6}$$

Here, $\boldsymbol{\mu}$ contains the operating and geometry parameters, $\mathbf{b}_q$ and $\mathbf{t}_q$ are the branch- and trunk-network outputs for output channel q, $\mathbf{x}$ is the query coordinate, and c_q is a learned bias [Lu et al., 2021]. The **PINN** has three tanh layers of width 64 and uses 1,024 sampled points per case. Its supervised loss is augmented by 10^{-4} times the full steady incompressible RANS continuity and mean-momentum residuals under a Boussinesq eddy-viscosity closure [Raissi et al., 2019]. Appendix A gives the exact implemented objective, including physical-unit denormalization, coordinate scaling, and residual nondimensionalization.

All models use AdamW with learning rate 2×10^{-3}, weight decay 10^{-4}, at most 120 epochs, patience 20, and gradient clipping. Each architecture is trained with seeds 7, 17, and 27 on the same split. Normalization uses training cases only. The best checkpoint is selected by validation loss. Model size ranges from 9,930 to 595,914 parameters (Table 1).

Data, targets, optimizer, stopping rule, and evaluation budget are shared, but parameter counts are reported rather than artificially matched: equal width is not equal capacity across convolutional, spectral, branch–trunk, and pointwise models. These are compact canonical configurations, and no hyperparameter is selected on the test families.

Optimization uses dedicated C_L and C_D output heads supervised by OpenFOAM's total force coefficients. Pressure integration on the coarse common grid is not used for the objective because it omits viscous traction and under-resolves the wall.

3.2 Common optimization protocol

At $Re = 5 \times 10^5$, each surrogate drives the same HSO loop. The design vector $\theta = (m, p, t, \alpha)$ contains maximum camber, camber location, thickness, and incidence, with bounds $m \in [0, 0.09]$, $p \in [0.1, 0.9]$, $t \in [0.06, 0.20]$, and $\alpha \in [-4, 10]^\circ$. We launch Nelder–Mead from NACA 0012, 2412, and 4415 and give every run the same 40-iteration budget [Nelder and Mead, 1965]. The objective is

$$J(\theta) = \frac{C_L}{|C_D| + 10^{-6}}. \tag{7}$$

The search calls only the surrogate; OpenFOAM is not used inside the loop, and cavitation margin is retained only as a secondary diagnostic. We return the best design observed within the fixed budget, select the strongest of the three starts for each architecture, and then generate a new mesh and independent OpenFOAM simulation for that winner.

The optimizer is continuous although the training geometries are discrete. It queries intermediate four-digit descriptors (m, p, t) within the stated bounds and can move beyond the convex coverage of the training families near a bound. We retain every query and independently remesh and solve each selected endpoint with CFD; this validates the reported design, not the full learned surface.

Table 1: Final-test RMSE (mean ± sample standard deviation over three seeds), size, and speedup.

Model	p (Pa)	C_p	C_L	C_D	Params. (k)	Speedup
CNN-U-Net	28.3 ± 14.2	$.066 \pm .037$	$.258 \pm .200$	$.0087 \pm .0052$	485	544 ± 13
PINN	11.3 ± 0.4	$.044 \pm .003$	$.036 \pm .005$	$.0035 \pm .0002$	**9.93**	665 ± 4
FNO	27.8 ± 1.1	$.064 \pm .004$	$.248 \pm .020$	$.0103 \pm .0005$	596	464 ± 6
DeepONet	10.7 ± 1.5	$.041 \pm .005$	$.030 \pm .008$	$.0034 \pm .0009$	101	384 ± 2

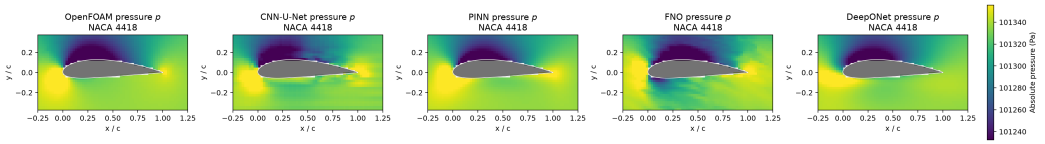


Figure 1: Absolute-pressure prediction for NACA 4418. The view spans $x/c \in [-0.25, 1.25]$ and $y/c \in [-0.375, 0.375]$.

The direct-CFD baseline repeats this protocol with the same starts, bounds, objective, tolerances, and 40-iteration budget, but OpenFOAM supplies every objective value. It is distinct from the one-solve endpoint checks of the surrogate winners. Appendix Figure 3 shows the complete best-so-far traces for every start and training seed.

4 Results

4.1 Final-test accuracy and computational cost

Table 1 reports mean and one sample standard deviation over three seeds on the untouched NACA 0018/4418 test set. DeepONet gives the lowest mean pressure, C_p, C_L, and C_D errors. The PINN is consistently second; CNN-U-Net is notably seed-sensitive.

Mean training times are 556, 283, 270, and 47 s for CNN-U-Net, the PINN, FNO, and DeepONet. Complete-field inference yields 384–665× speedups over the measured OpenFOAM cases. The benchmark used an 8-core Apple M2 Mac mini with 16 GB memory; PyTorch ran on CPU and OpenFOAM 9 ran in Docker.

Figure 1 shows a case from the unseen NACA 4418 family. The pointwise models reproduce the leading-edge pressure structure most closely; CNN-U-Net smooths the extrema and FNO introduces spatial texture.

4.2 Cavitation-inception screening

The pressure-threshold labels are highly imbalanced, so we report F1 rather than accuracy. DeepONet obtains 0.900 ± 0.008, the PINN 0.859 ± 0.015, CNN-U-Net 0.758 ± 0.198, and FNO 0.724 ± 0.065. This is a secondary low-C_p diagnostic, not a prediction of cavity dynamics [Brennen, 1995].

4.3 Shape optimization against direct CFD

Figure 2 reports the complete L/D comparison: the OpenFOAM value of the starting foil, the surrogate estimate at its selected design, and the result of remeshing that design and solving it once in OpenFOAM. This one-solve endpoint check is distinct from the direct baseline, which places OpenFOAM inside the matched optimizer.

Across three selected endpoints per architecture, medium-grid OpenFOAM gives $L/D = 24.44 \pm 1.35$ for CNN-U-Net, 36.85 ± 5.09 for the PINN, 22.10 ± 3.46 for FNO, and 37.47 ± 5.95 for DeepONet. The matched direct-CFD search reaches 29.89. These values are not mesh-independent: on the seed-7 winners, medium-to-fine L/D shifts are 16–22%.

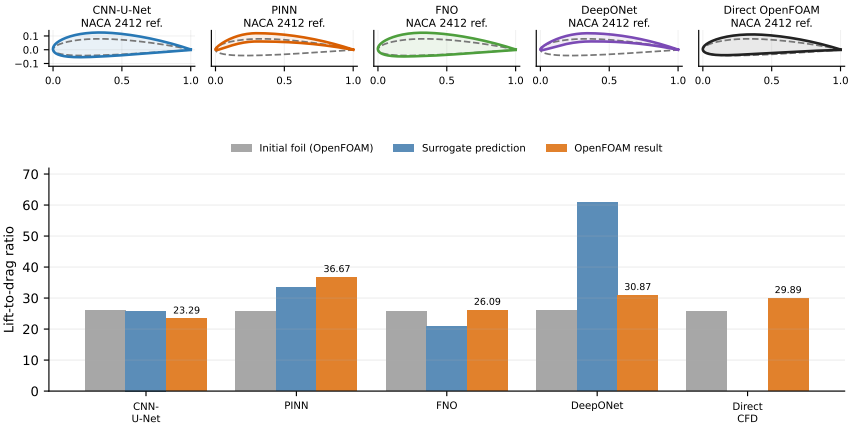


Figure 2: Top: selected shapes against the same dashed NACA 2412 geometric reference. The reference is for visual comparison, not necessarily the optimizer initializer. Bottom: initial-foil OpenFOAM values, surrogate predictions, fresh OpenFOAM endpoint checks, and direct CFD.

5 Discussion

DeepONet is the best final-test predictor, while its optimized endpoints and those of the PINN both vary across seeds. CNN-U-Net is unstable in both force prediction and optimization; FNO is more repeatable but selects lower-performing designs. Accuracy, candidate ranking, and seed robustness are therefore distinct.

All 12 grid-study runs converge iteratively by 1,000 iterations, with final residuals below 10^{-7} and negligible late force drift. Lift changes by at most about 4% from medium to fine, but drag changes by 16–26%. Thus, a fresh OpenFOAM endpoint is a standard and useful verification step, yet it is not by itself a grid-independent validation. This is precisely the simulator imperfection exposed by carrying the benchmark through the design loop.

The continuous optimizer also queries descriptors between and near the bounds of twelve discrete families. Endpoint CFD checks the selected shape, not the entire learned surface. All winners remain far from vapor pressure, so cavitation is a secondary diagnostic rather than an active constraint. The remaining scope is steady 2D RANS and the NACA four-digit space.

6 Conclusion

While standard benchmarks rank neural flow surrogates by field and force errors—where DeepONet excels and the compact PINN dominates in speed—our end-to-end evaluation reveals a critical blind spot. Pushing these models through a multi-start optimization loop demonstrates that isolated test accuracy does not reliably predict downstream design decisions or seed robustness. To truly bridge machine learning and scientific engineering, surrogates must be evaluated on their operational consequences and the numerical uncertainty of the verifying simulator. Future work will advance this paradigm through three-dimensional flows and active cavitation-constrained optimization.

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A PINN objective

The network predicts normalized outputs, but the residuals are evaluated after velocity and pressure are returned to physical units. For output channel q,

$$q = \sigma_q \widehat{q} + \mu_q, \qquad \frac{\partial q}{\partial x_i} = \frac{\sigma_q}{\sigma_{x_i}} \frac{\partial \widehat{q}}{\partial \widehat{x}_i}, \tag{8}$$

where the means and standard deviations are computed from the training set. Comma subscripts denote partial spatial derivatives. Let $\nu_e = \nu + \max(\nu_t, 0)$. The modeled kinematic stresses are

$$\tau_{xx} = 2\nu_e U_{x,x}, \qquad \tau_{xy} = \nu_e (U_{x,y} + U_{y,x}), \tag{9}$$

$$\tau_{yy} = 2\nu_e U_{y,y}. \tag{10}$$

The sampled-point continuity and momentum residuals are

$$r_c = U_{x,x} + U_{y,y}, \tag{11}$$

$$r_x = U_x U_{x,x} + U_y U_{x,y} + p_{,x}/\rho - \tau_{xx,x} - \tau_{xy,y}, \tag{12}$$

$$r_y = U_x U_{y,x} + U_y U_{y,y} + p_{,y}/\rho - \tau_{xy,x} - \tau_{yy,y}. \tag{13}$$

For chord c and casewise freestream speed U_∞, the combined objective is

$$\mathcal{L} = \mathcal{L}_{\text{sup}} + 10^{-4} \left[\text{MSE}\left(\frac{c r_c}{U_\infty} \right) + \text{MSE}\left(\frac{c r_x}{U_\infty^2} \right) + \text{MSE}\left(\frac{c r_y}{U_\infty^2} \right) \right]. \tag{14}$$

B Complete optimization traces

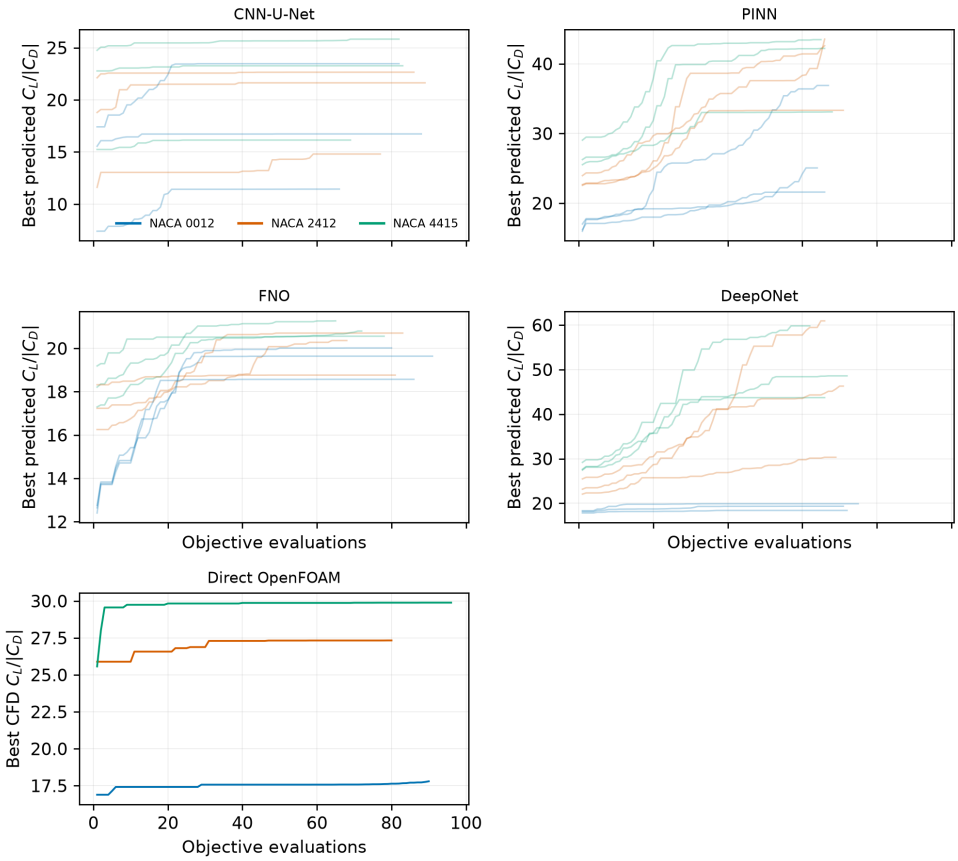


Figure 3: All three optimization starts and three training seeds per surrogate, with the three direct-CFD starts. Lines show best-so-far objective; every raw evaluation is included in the anonymous artifact.

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